



The many lives of Colombo

A journey through Colombo during India's Test tour of Sri Lanka, taking in its historic clubs, sudden rains, tuk-tuks, food, currency and the **many moods** of the city.

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In an island-nation with its lone metropolis being the capital, Colombo inevitably has many historical outposts, specifically sporting venues steeped in colonial flavour and coastal warmth. With a First-Class cricket structure leaning on the clubs rather than provinces or States, every club has its own ground with a pavilion and club-house.

If the turf echoes to the sound of a red-cherry

thudding into a bat during the day, at night the terrace stirs awake to the clinking of glasses and the placement of cutlery to dig into both Sri Lankan and continental cuisine. Fried cashew-nuts laced with spice, salt and a generous helping of curry leaves are a favourite accompaniment as beverages get sipped and laughter echoes across tables.

Around the Sinhalese Sports Club (SSC) Ground, the venue for the second and final Test involving host Sri Lanka and India, there are many other clubs which are a stone's throw away. Some will be packed with office-goers stepping in to unwind before heading home; others will have old-time members, sticklers for protocol and etiquette.

And

every club will do hat-tips to history, which isn't surprising as most of them are more than a 100 years old. Wooden walls with engraved names of cricketers are a second skin to all these clubs. And since a Test is on, often conversations veer towards what Shubman Gill's men did against Dhananjaya de Silva's unit.

The cost of a weak currency

An Alto could cost anywhere up to 37 lakh Sri Lankan rupees. The ride to the ground or back home is inevitably in a small car that either carries a Suzuki or Toyota badge. Drivers, if they are not glued to their phones, make small-talk. Often it is about the cost of the vehicle and, when told about prices in India, there is shock and awe. "Oh, but in Sri Lanka tax is too much, too much," will be the reply in that sing-song English with a heavy Sinhalese accent.

Tuk-tuks, basically